Attention training at work: what the research shows

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This document sets out the figures we use for attention training. Every figure appears word for word in the source next to it. Each one also says what kind of study it comes from, and who was measured. Our own estimates and projections are not included.

1. Research among others

These figures come from studies of attention training. They were not measured in Innerleaps participants. Results differ per organisation.

Figure	What	Type of study	Source
-69%	Sick days in the past 3 months, training group (4.57 to 1.40). Control group: 3.84 to 3.69. Self-reported, measured after about 3 months.	Randomised, 144 middle managers in Poland, 8-week training (3-hour sessions plus one full day)	Żołnierczyk-Zreda et al., 2016
54.4% → 16.4%	Share of participants at increased risk of long-term absence through illness, 6 months after the training.	Not randomised, 150 Unilever employees, 8 weeks; their own waiting period as comparison	De Bruin et al., 2018
89.8%	Intended to keep practising afterwards, of those who answered (58.7% of all participants).	Same study	De Bruin et al., 2018
-26.4%	Perceived stress in the trained group, straight after the training (-23.1% after 6 months).	Randomised, 89 Dow Chemical employees, online training	Aikens et al., 2014
up to 12 months	Studies that measured between 3 months and a year after the training still found less stress than in the control group. Productivity slightly higher straight after the training.	Meta-analysis of 91 randomised studies at work	Michaelsen et al., 2023
65 to 72%	Chance that someone who did the training has less stress than someone who didn't. Converted by us from the effect sizes.	Meta-analyses of randomised studies	Vonderlin et al., 2020; De Vibe et al., 2017; Bartlett et al., 2019

-25%	Errors on concentration tasks among people who practised 12 minutes a day.	Described in a book about her research	Jha, 2021 (Peak Mind)
4.7%	Still uses an app for attention exercises after 30 days (all mental health apps: 3.3%).	Usage data from 93 apps	Baumel et al., 2019

2. Sickness absence in the Netherlands

- Absence was **5.6%** of working days in the fourth quarter of 2025 (Statistics Netherlands, CBS).
- **One in four** days of sickness absence is linked to stress, according to figures from ArboNed and HumanCapitalCare covering about 1 million employees (July 2024 to June 2025).

3. Our own measurement: TheyDo

TheyDo is a fully remote tech scale-up. 39 employees took part in the 6-week training in spring 2026.

- **+8.6% productivity**, 4 weeks after the training. Self-reported with the WHO Health and Work Performance Questionnaire, n=14.
- **68%** noticed less stress and tension, 55% less time on autopilot, 55% less mental fatigue, 41% better concentration. Self-reported in the end-of-training evaluation, n=22 of 39, in 5 groups.
- Trainer rated 9.3 on average, programme 8.1.

Limitations. There is no control group: we compare participants with themselves, before and after. So we can't say whether a change was caused by the training. Everything is self-reported, not everyone filled in the questionnaires, and the groups are small. Results differ per organisation and are no guarantee.

4. When does the training pay for itself?

We don't calculate an expected saving, because we can't promise one. We only calculate the break-even point: the cost of the training against the participants' salaries.

Break-even in productivity = price per participant ÷ average gross annual salary
Break-even in sick days = price per participant ÷ (gross annual salary ÷ 260 working days)

Example: at €575 per participant and an average salary of €40,000, the training pays for itself from 1.44% more productivity, or if each participant has 3.7 fewer sick days a year. At TheyDo the break-even point was 0.36%; participants reported 8.6%. Work it out for your own organisation at innerleaps.nl.

Sources

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More on how we measure and what the figures don't tell you: innerleaps.nl/en/methodology